Teaching Philosophy

In graduate school, I have developed as both a researcher and a teacher, two professional capacities that mutually reinforce one another. At Duke, I served as a teaching assistant, accumulating over 75 hours of independent classroom instruction, and completed Duke's Certificate in College Teaching, which included over 40 hours of structured pedagogy training, as well as peer feedback and supervision (A5, V5). I am guided by the belief that education should spark intellectual curiosity and equip students with the skills to thrive both inside and beyond the classroom. This value shapes how I design courses (A1), lead lectures (A2), assess students (A3), and provide mentorship (A4).

Design Exercises with Real World Examples

I design my coursework to maximize student engagement by connecting academic concepts to real-world cases through historical case studies, current event discussions, and interactive simulations (A1,V2). In my 15-student discussion sections for *Introduction to International Relations* and *American Foreign Policy*, I led weekly discussions using case studies to illustrate core concepts (V2), often drawing on my expertise of the Middle East. For example, in October 2024, we discussed how "rationalist explanations of war," particularly the commitment problem, helps explain Israel's offensive against Hezbollah in Lebanon and its broader foreign policy toward Iran and its proxies. Similarly, as a TA in *Comparative Political Behavior*, I designed in-class exercises to help students engage with the assigned readings. During a class on the effects of gender attitudes on vote choice, students designed their own conjoint survey experiment. They created attributes of hypothetical candidates for student body president, which I then coded into Qualtrics, fielded to the class, analyzed, and presented back to them (K4). This exercise deepened students' understanding of gender and voting behavior, demystified the research process (V1, K2), and provided hands-on training in a research method used in academia and industry (V4, K4).

Teaching Politics in a Polarized Environment

A major difficulty in teaching political science with real-world examples is that the subject matter is, well… political (A2, V4). How can we examine salient topics without being dragged into two-dimensional debates of today's polarized atmosphere? (K3) Points of discussion must be salient enough to engage students; however, issues can't be so charged that they preclude diverse engagement (V2). As an educator, I have developed approaches to facilitate a balanced, healthy dialogue.

One approach is to establish a norm that discussions are structured around assigned readings and focused on a relatively narrow question (V2). For example, when teaching International Relations in early 2024 during the onset of the Israel–Gaza conflict, the instructor and I chose not to avoid the topic entirely. Instead, American support for Israel was introduced as a case study on how special interest groups shape U.S. foreign policy. This focused discussion avoided debate about the broader conflict. Another strategy I have used is providing low stakes running examples (V1, K2). When teaching Comparative Political Behavior, I often drew on the bitter but ultimately innocuous Duke–UNC rivalry. School identity provided a useful entry point for discussing potentially charged questions: Where does identity come from? Is it fluid or multifaceted? How does conflict fuel identity, and how does identity fuel conflict? I also

incorporated this example into simulations, using Duke versus UNC as in-groups and out-groups in behavioral games (K2, K4). In these exercises, students allocated resources to others with randomly assigned identities, helping them understand concepts such as parochial altruism.

Ultimately, navigating the classroom is a dynamic process that depends on the views and personalities of students, which vary from class to class and year to year. The better you know your students, the better you can navigate this environment.

Being an Approachable, Relatable Mentor

My younger self serves as my greatest motivation to excel as an educator and advisor (A4). My alma mater, The University of Arkansas, is a large public university which, at the time, lacked a political science department offering training in quantitative methods or faculty aligned with my research interests. Ten years later, I can still feel the visceral frustration of struggling through my senior thesis without formal training or mentorship. I still remember learning how to read academic articles, navigate formulas and regression tables, and write a literature review. I believe that navigating these challenges without structured mentorship makes me more relatable to my students (V1). By emphasizing that I have been in their shoes, I cultivate an approachable classroom environment in which students feel comfortable asking questions and making mistakes. In teaching evaluations my students have noted that I am "compassionate, funny, knowledgeable, and kind… [have] been there to assist and help out every step of the way."

One practical way I provide guidance on writing and research is by sharing the practical tricks and insights I've learned along the way (K2). For example, in the first class of every semester, I lead a discussion on how to read an academic article. I provide my students with five guiding questions to help them extract the key elements of an academic article (K1). This template goes a long way in helping students properly digest the assigned readings. Additionally, each semester I meet with interested students over coffee to discuss their senior thesis and career interests. We often discuss how to identify a research question, what a literature review entails, what academia is like, and what job prospects may look like. I find mentorship—whether in the classroom or through working with undergraduate research assistants—to be a rewarding part of academia. While publishing research takes years, teaching and advising provide immediate gratification with a visible impact.

Assessing Students in the Era of AI

Evaluation is a key component of being an effective educator (A3). The formal purpose of grading is to assign students credit and record their performance on a transcript. Its substantive purpose, however, is to cultivate critical thinking, strengthen writing skills, and deepen students' understanding of politics. Students should leave my courses with a deeper understanding of history, an ability to engage critically with academic research, and the ability to apply insights from political science to contemporary challenges. The goal of evaluation is to coach them through these tasks (A4), so they develop as both consumers and creators of knowledge.

Evaluation is most effective through face-to-face engagement and detailed written feedback (A3). Accordingly, I devoted substantial time to this work as a TA. In *Comparative Political Behavior*, 20 students each completed three 300-word essays over the semester. In response, I

provided over 20,000 words of written feedback, supplemented by in-person meetings to discuss grades and comments (A3).

Generative AI, however, provides students with shortcuts that can reduce the friction needed to develop transferable skills (K4). As a TA, I have collaborated with instructors of record to adapt course syllabi to incorporate AI while establishing clear guardrails on its use. Students are encouraged to use AI, but to do so selectively. In one lecture, we structured an exercise in which half the class careful read and evaluated an academic article using the "five guiding questions" approach, while the other half relied on an AI tool to generate an critical summary. We then compared results as a group, highlighting both the strengths and limitations of AI for this task. At the same time, assessment requires clear restrictions on AI to ensure students acquire a genuine understanding of the course's content. Quizzes and exams are completed in class using pen and paper, requiring students to recall information and construct arguments without the assistance of technology.

The challenges posed by AI extend beyond written assignments to classroom discussions. For example, as part of Duke's Certificate in College Teaching, I participated in "Teaching Triangles," in which a peer evaluated my performance as a discussion section leader for *Introduction to International Relations* (K3, V5). On that day, I facilitated a discussion on the effectiveness of third-party peacekeeping in civil conflict. My peer observer, seated at the back of the room, later noted that one student had been entering my discussion questions verbatim into an AI platform and then responding in class with the generated answers. In response, I began incorporating portions of discussion sections in which students closed their laptops and engaged directly with the material without digital tools.

Teaching Interests

With expertise in political behavior during conflict and authoritarianism, I am well prepared to teach undergraduate courses in Comparative Politics and International Relations. At Duke, I served as a discussion section leader for *Introduction to International Relations* and *American Foreign Policy*, and as a teaching assistant for *Introduction to Comparative Political Behavior*. I would be eager to teach these courses as a professor as well. In addition, I have devoted considerable attention to learning and communicating quantitative methods and would welcome the opportunity to teach an undergraduate methodology course covering the fundamentals of research design and quantitative analysis, including the basics of regression and causal inference.

I would also be excited to develop upper-level undergraduate and graduate seminars in my areas of expertise. For example, I could offer a course on the *Politics of the Middle East* drawing on my firsthand experience in the region, as well as seminars on *Migration and Displacement* and *Political Violence: Attitudes and Behavior*, informed by my parallel research agendas. Finally, as a first-generation graduate student, I am particularly committed to mentoring students interested in pursuing research at both the undergraduate and graduate levels—whether navigating the challenges of fieldwork, wrangling data, or managing the practical details of completing a dissertation.